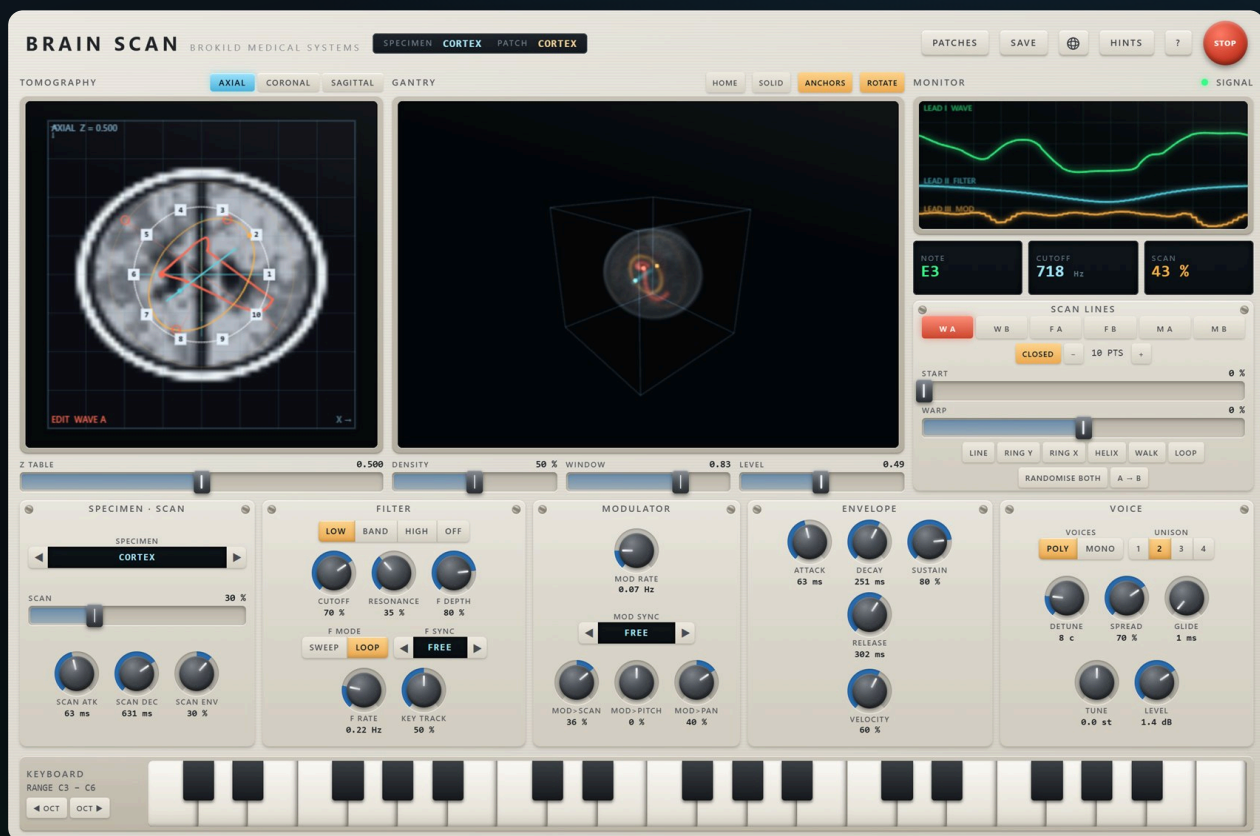


BRAIN SCAN

A synth that stores no waveforms. A specimen is a volume; a scan line is a curve through it; one cycle of the sound is the field along that curve. The filter's cutoff and the modulator are the same thing read slower. And SCAN blends the geometry of two lines, so halfway between two sounds is tissue neither of them has visited.



BRAIN SCAN

nine specimens · three scanners · six lines · tomography · gantry · world rack

BROKILD

free · VST3 + standalone · 64-bit

A wavetable synth stores a waveform and reads it with a phasor. To move between two sounds it crossfades two answers. Brain Scan keeps the idea of a stored thing and changes what is stored, and the whole instrument follows from that one change.

A specimen is a volume. Not a table of samples but a scalar field $V(x,y,z)$ filling a cube — a density, exactly like the numbers a scanner records. Nine of them ship: seven are fields designed to give ordinary, useful waveforms, one is a hollow shell, and one is a simulated brain, with skull, cortical folds, a fissure and ventricles.

A scan line is a curve through it. Two to sixteen control points with a smooth curve through them, open or closed. One cycle of the waveform is the field read along that curve: $w(s) = V(g(s))$, where s is the phase. Drive the curve straight across the cube and you read the specimen's natural waveform. Bend it, loop it, tangle it, and you read something the specimen contains but nobody put there on purpose.

What the geometry gives you for nothing

- A **closed loop** has no edge, so the cycle joins itself: soft.
- An **open segment** jumps between its ends once per cycle: bright, saw-like. That jump is band-limited so it does not alias.

- A **corner** is a kink at a fixed phase.
- A **self-crossing** is one value visited at two phases.
- **WARP** reads the same shape unevenly: phase distortion, free.
- Move the whole line and the timbre evolves while the instrument stays itself.

The claim, and how it is different

SCAN blends the positions, not the samples. Every scanner has two anchor lines, A and B. At SCAN 50 % the instrument does not mix the two waveforms; it builds the line halfway between the two *curves* and reads the field once, along that. A wavetable crossfades two answers. This moves the question.

It is measurable, and it is measured. Take two pulses of duty 0.23 and 0.77. Both have a null at the fifth harmonic, so any crossfade of them keeps that null: the bench reads it at -66 dB. The midway *path* reads a pulse of duty 0.50, whose fifth harmonic is -14.0 dB, exactly the formula. Fifty decibels of difference, from the same two endpoints.

The filter and the modulator are the same mechanism read slower. The cutoff is a scan line traversed once per note, or looping; so is the modulator. Three scanners, six lines, one law, and one SCAN control that moves all three at once.

02 Thirty seconds of instructions

START HERE

Play something. The keyboard along the bottom is playable with the mouse, and the computer keys work too: **z x c v** for the lower octave, **q w e r** for the one above. The instrument opens on a patch called **ADMISSION**.

Turn SCAN. It is the wide slider under **SPECIMEN**, on the left of the desk. Watch the bright line on the slice move between its two dim anchors while the sound travels. That is the whole instrument in one gesture.

Change the specimen. The window at the top left of the desk steps through the nine. The gantry and the slice reload; the lines stay where they are, so the same drawing reads a different body.

Draw. Pick **W A** in the **SCAN LINES** panel, then work on the tomography slice: drag a numbered point to move it, click bare tissue to add one, alt-click a point to take it away. A point keeps its depth when dragged; the **TABLE** slider decides which depth new points land at.

Give SCAN somewhere to go. RANDOMISE BOTH draws fresh walks for both anchors of the selected scanner. **A → B** copies A onto B so you can nudge B away from a shape you already like.

The four regions

Left, the **tomography**: one plane through the specimen, and the only place lines are edited. Middle, the **gantry**: the specimen in three dimensions with the lines glowing inside it — for looking, not for editing. Right, the **monitor** and the **scan lines** bench. Below, the **desk**: specimen and scan, filter, modulator, envelope, voice.

Every control says what it is. Hover anything — a knob, a button, a tab, the slice itself — and a note appears beside it saying what it does and how it is used. The **HINTS** button in the header turns them off; so does the **?** key.

If it goes wrong. The red mushroom stops every voice. Double-click any knob for its default.

PATCHES holds nine factory studies and everything in your patch folder.



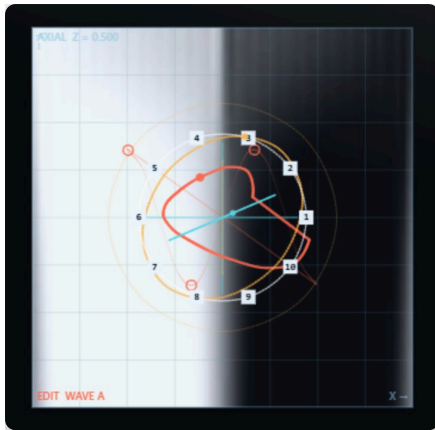
03 The nine specimens

The x axis is the phase axis. A straight line along x reads the specimen's natural waveform at whatever (y, z) it sits at, so an ordinary wavetable is a special case: a straight line, moved sideways. The other two axes are the timbre axes and each specimen says what they mean.

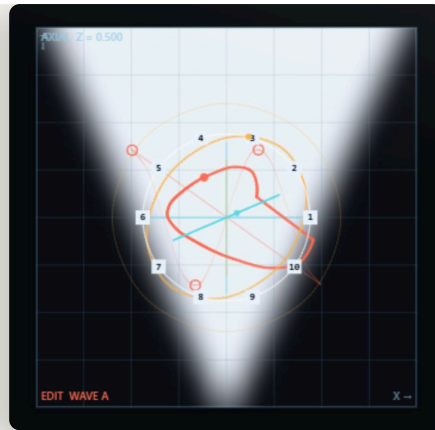
SPECIMEN	A STRAIGHT LINE READS	Y	Z
SINUS	a sine	amplitude	a touch of second harmonic
SPINE	a harmonic stack	brightness	parity: saw to square
PULSE	a pulse	width, 5–95 %	edge softness
MARROW	a ramp	curvature	folds toward a triangle
NERVE	a phase-modulated sine	index	modulator ratio
RETINA	two decaying formants	first formant	second formant
LUNG	smooth noise	rough, breathy, metallic on a loop	
SKULL	a hollow sphere	two bumps per cycle through the centre	
CORTEX	the brain	skull, folds, fissure, ventricles	

Musically normal by construction. SPINE at a given (y, z) is exactly a harmonic series with a known rolloff and a known parity; PULSE at a given y is exactly a pulse of a known width. The bench checks both against their formulas — the duty cycle lands within 0.001 of what the formula says. SPINE is the instrument's bread.

CORTEX is the show-piece, not a wavetable. A line through a brain reads bone, then fluid, then folded cortex, then a ventricle: a waveform with a hard edge, a smooth stretch, a burst of detail and a plateau, and moving the line an inch changes which of those it meets and in what order. It is not designed to be tidy. It is designed to be somewhere.



SPINE — a harmonic stack, sliced



PULSE — width across y



CORTEX — the simulated brain

04 The three scanners, and the one SCAN

THE
MECHANISM

SCANNER	READS	RATE
WAVE	the audio waveform	once per cycle of the note
FILTER	the cutoff of the filter	once per note (SWEEP), or looping (LOOP)
MOD	a modulator: scan, pitch, pan	looping, free or on the host clock

Each has two anchors, A and B. **SCAN** is where between them every scanner is read, and it moves all three together. It has three sources that add up:

- the **SCAN** slider, the base position;
- the **scan envelope** — SCAN ATK, SCAN DEC and SCAN ENV, which is bipolar, so the envelope can

travel toward B or back toward A;

- MOD>SCAN**, the modulator's own contribution.

Because the blend is of geometry, a scan envelope is not a filter sweep and not a crossfade. It is the reading head travelling through the specimen while the note sounds, and what it finds on the way is whatever is there.

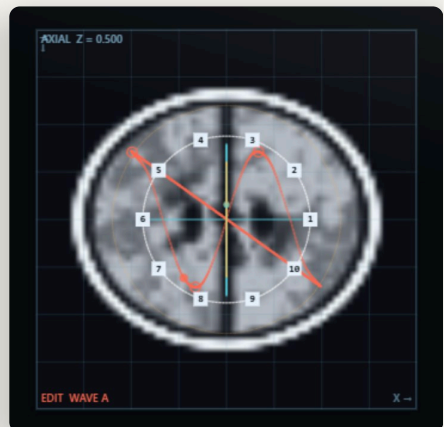
Why the anchors matter more than the knobs.
Two anchors that lie on top of each other give a SCAN that does nothing. Two anchors in different rooms of the specimen give a SCAN that is the most powerful control on the panel. RANDOMISE BOTH exists for this reason, and it is the fastest way to find out what a specimen contains.



SCAN 0 — read at anchor A



SCAN 50 % — a line neither anchor draws



SCAN 100 % — read at anchor B

The bright line is what is being read. The two faint ones are the anchors; the numbered squares are the control points of the line being edited.

A curve in a cube cannot be drawn with a mouse — but a curve on a plane can, and a plane can be driven through the cube. That is what the tomograph is for, and it is the only place lines are edited.

The plane

AXIAL, **CORONAL** and **SAGITTAL** cut the volume on XY, XZ and YZ. The **TABLE** slider under the slice drives the plane through the specimen; so does the wheel over the slice. The heading in the corner always says which plane and which depth.

The gestures

- **Drag a numbered point** to move it in this plane. *Its depth is kept* — you are moving it on the plane, not to the plane.
- **Click bare tissue** to add a point at the plane's current depth, inserted into the segment it is nearest to.
- **Alt-click a point** to remove it. Two is the minimum.
- **Wheel** moves the table. Hold shift for one texel at a time.

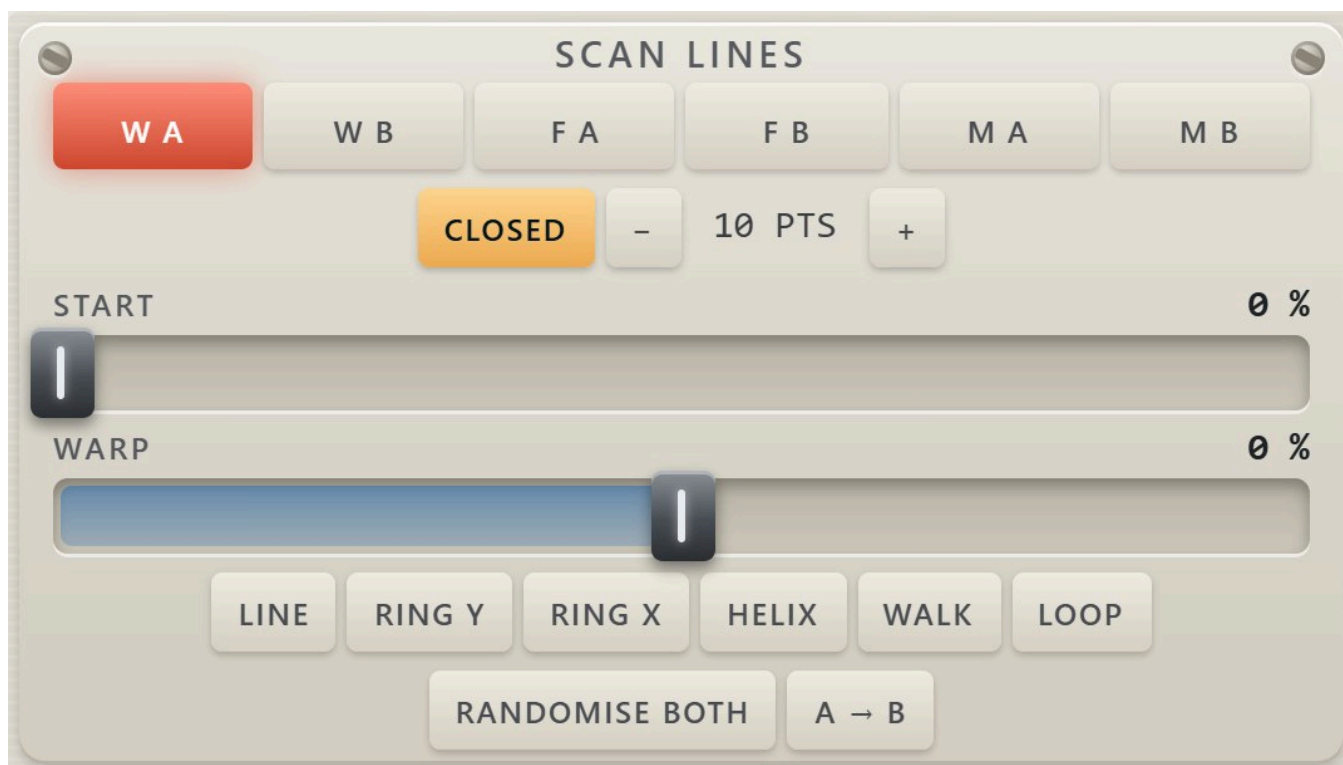
Points off the plane are drawn hollow and fade with distance, so you can always see where the rest of

the line has got to. Every line's crossing of the current plane is ringed in that scanner's colour — red for WAVE, cyan for FILTER, amber for MOD.

The bench

The **SCAN LINES** panel on the right chooses which of the six lines you are editing and carries its own properties.

CLOSED	loop or segment — no edge, or one edge per cycle
- / +	take a point off the end, or add one; two to sixteen
START	where a closed loop's cycle begins: moves the phase, not the shape
WARP	phase distortion — the reader runs faster over one half of the line
LINE ... LOOP	lay a shape through the line's present centre. WALK and LOOP are new every time you press them
RANDOMISE BOTH	fresh walks for both anchors of this scanner
A → B	copy this scanner's A anchor onto its B anchor



The scan-line bench. Six lines, and the tools for the one you are editing.



CORONAL — the same lines, cut on XZ



SAGITTAL — cut on YZ



The tomograph and its table

The middle screen is the specimen in three dimensions, ray-marched, with the scan lines glowing inside it. It is for looking: nothing is edited here. Drag to turn the specimen, wheel to come closer, **HOME** to put it back, **ROTATE** to let it turn on its own.

The bright line is what is being read at the present **SCAN**; the two dimmer ones are its anchors, and **ANCHORS** hides them. The small travelling dots are the reading heads — the audio-rate one shown slowed down, because nothing about 300 revolutions a second is watchable.

DENSITY, WINDOW and LEVEL

These three are the transfer function, and they are the scanner's own vocabulary.

- **DENSITY** is opacity. Low, and the specimen is a ghost the lines blaze through; high, and the tissue closes over them.
- **WINDOW** is the window's *width* — how much of the density range is shown at all.
- **LEVEL** is the window's *centre* — which density it is looking at.

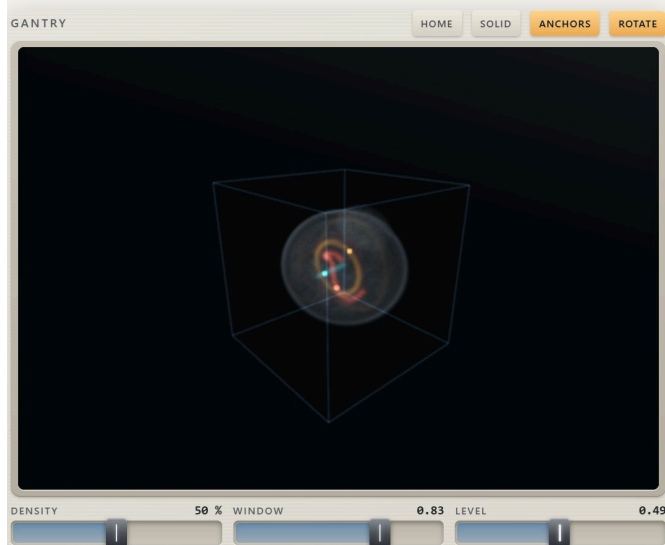
WINDOW and **LEVEL** also drive the slice, exactly as a window and level pair drives a real radiograph. They are set for you when a specimen loads, from that specimen's own histogram, and then stay where you put them until the next one.

SOLID and SURFACE

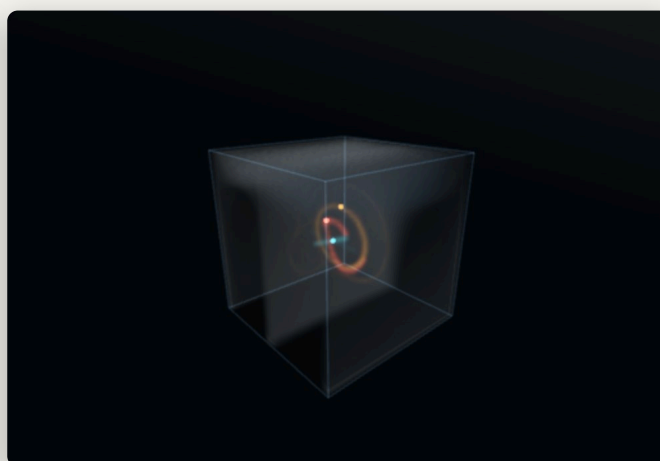
A specimen with air around it and a specimen whose field fills the cube want opposite treatments, so the treatment is a button.

- **SOLID** shows everything denser than the window's floor. That is how a scanned object should read: the brain, the skull.
- **SURFACE** is opaque only in the middle of the window, so a field that fills the cube becomes the single surface where it crosses the level. Sweep **LEVEL** in this mode and you travel out through the specimen one shell at a time.

It is chosen for you when a specimen loads — **SOLID** if more than a third of the cube is empty — and you can override it.



CORTEX in **SOLID**, the lines glowing through



SPINE in **SURFACE** — one level of the field

FILTER

A state-variable filter with **LOW**, **BAND**, **HIGH** and **OFF**. **CUTOFF** is where it sits when the **FILTER** line has no say; **F DEPTH** is how much of the say the line has. At **F DEPTH** 0 the filter is an ordinary filter. Turn it up and the cutoff becomes a reading of the specimen along the **FILTER** line — which means a filter sweep with the shape of whatever the line passes through, not a curve from a table.

F MODE chooses **SWEEP**, one traversal per note, or **LOOP**, going round for as long as the note lasts. **F RATE** is the sweep time or the loop rate, and **F SYNC** locks the loop to the host clock. **KEY TRACK** is how much the cutoff follows the note.

MODULATOR

A third line, read at **MOD RATE** (or on the host clock through **MOD SYNC**), whose reading is sent three places: **MOD>SCAN**, **MOD>PITCH** and **MOD>PAN**. All three are bipolar. A modulator whose line loops through a rough part of the specimen is a very different animal from one that

loops through a smooth part; the shape of the modulation is the shape of the tissue.

ENVELOPE and VOICE

ATTACK, **DECAY**, **SUSTAIN** and **RELEASE** with **VELOCITY** sensitivity, and the usual voice controls: **POLY** (eight voices) or **MONO** with legato glide, **UNISON** of one to four readers per note, **DETUNE** and **SPREAD** for them, **GLIDE**, **TUNE** and **LEVEL**.

Unison is literal here. Four readers walk the same line at slightly different rates. They are reading the same tissue, so they stay related to one another however strange the line is.

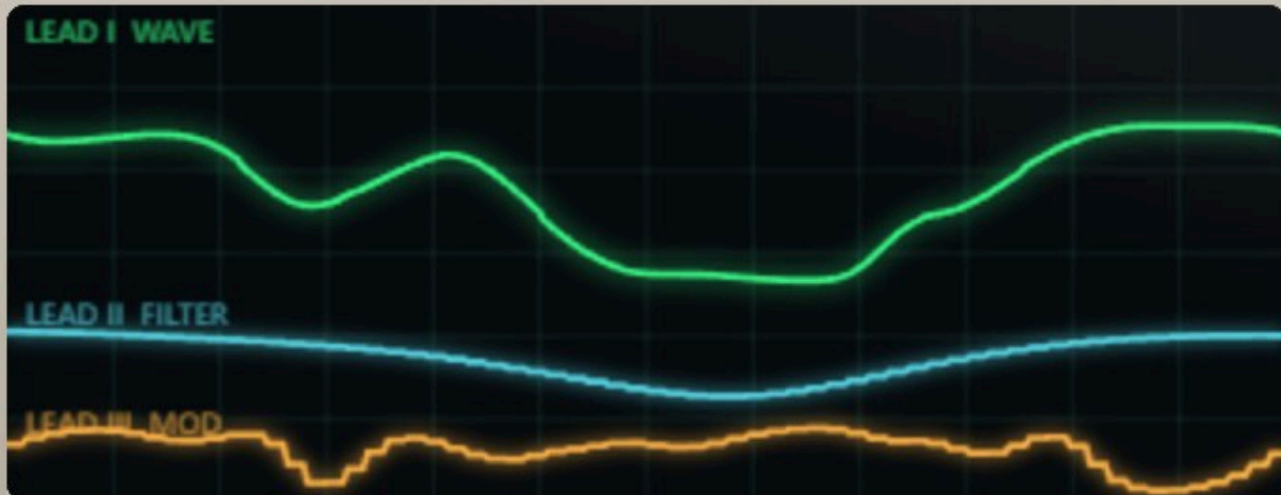
The monitor

Three leads: **LEAD I** is the cycle the **WAVE** scanner is reading, **LEAD II** the **FILTER** line, **LEAD III** the **MOD** line. Under them, the note being played, the cutoff in hertz, and where **SCAN** has actually got to — which is not the same as where the slider is, once the envelope and the modulator have had their say.



MONITOR

● SIGNAL



NOTE

E3

CUTOFF

581 Hz

SCAN

37 %

SCAN LINES

W A

W B

F A

F B

M A

M B

CLOSED

-

10 PTS

+

START

0 %

WARP

0 %

LINE

RING Y

RING X

HELIX

WALK

LOOP

RANDOMISE BOTH

A → B

The monitor, the vitals, and the scan-line bench.

PATCHES in the header holds nine factory studies and everything in your patch folder. A patch is every control, both anchors of all three scanners, the specimen and the rack — the whole machine. **SAVE** writes one.

Patches live in `Documents\Brokild patches\Brain Scan`, the same house folder every Brokild plug-in uses. You can point the plug-in somewhere else from the **PATCHES** menu, and it will remember. A patch is plain JSON; it can be sent to somebody.

ADMISSION	where a fresh instance opens
SINUS RHYTHM	a sine that will not sit still
CORTEX	the brain, played as an instrument
PULSE OX	width where width is not a knob
MARROW	the ramp, folded
NERVE	phase modulation read as a landscape
RETINAL	two formants and a scan between them
VENTILATOR	slow, breathing, on the host clock
ARRHYTHMIA	a line that should not work

Brokild World FX

The globe in the header opens the shared rack every Brokild instrument carries: twelve effect modules and four character modules, dragged into whatever order you like, and five **MACROS** that appear as host parameters so the rack can be automated. A fresh rack is empty and changes nothing.

Five macros, and they map rather than add. A macro sweeps its destination across the destination's whole range, so a macro at 100 % is that control at its top and 0 % is its bottom. **MACRO 5** arrives assigned to the rack's dry/wet, which is why a fresh instance sounds exactly as it would with no rack at all.



Brokild World FX, over the console.

Nothing in this manual is a claim somebody thought sounded right. The engine has an offline bench that renders real audio and asserts on it — 38 checks — and the panel has a second one that loads the real page and drives it through the plug-in's own message vocabulary — 24 checks. Both are in the source tree.

WHAT	MEASURED
SINUS is a sine	total harmonic distortion –120.8 dB
SPINE obeys its formula	centroid rises with y; at z = 1 the even harmonics sit 47.4 dB under the odd
PULSE obeys its width	duty 0.229 / 0.500 / 0.771 against a formula saying 0.230 / 0.500 / 0.770
Aliasing	the roughest specimen at C6: non-harmonic energy –70.0 dB, and –26.0 dB with the mip pyramid disabled
The edge of an open line	–53.4 dB with the band- limiting step, –20.0 dB without: it is worth 33 dB
Offset	–122.9 dB of DC after a second
The claim	the fifth harmonic at SCAN 50 %: –14.0 dB, the formula –14.0; the crossfade of the same two anchors –65.8
The filter follows its line	worst error 0.000 octaves against the field read along the blended line
Cost	11.0 % of one core for eight voices of four-way unison — 32 readers, the maximum

One number is worth reading twice. The mip pyramid — reading the volume at a coarseness matched to the pitch and the length of the path — is worth 44 dB of aliasing at C6. A volume read naively at high pitch is not a slightly rougher instrument; it is a broken one.

The panel probe checks, among other things, that a straight line of four collinear control points reads exactly straight — that the panel evaluates a curve the same way the engine does, to five decimal places. What you see drawn is what you hear.

10 Every control

REFERENCE

SPECIMEN · SCAN

SPECIMEN	which volume the lines read. Not automatable: it rebuilds a quarter of a million texels, and a lane fighting that is unusable
SCAN	where between A and B every scanner is read
SCAN ATK	how fast the scan envelope rises
SCAN DEC	how fast it falls back
SCAN ENV	how far the envelope moves the scan, either way $\pm 100\%$

FILTER

FILTER	LOW, BAND, HIGH, OFF
CUTOFF	the cutoff when the FILTER line has no say
RESONANCE	the filter's resonance
F DEPTH	how much the FILTER line decides the cutoff
F MODE	SWEEP once per note, or LOOP
F RATE	the sweep time, or the loop rate, 0.05–40 Hz
F SYNC	FREE, or 4/1 down to 1/16 and the triplets
KEY TRACK	how much the cutoff follows the note

MODULATOR

MOD RATE	how fast the MOD line is read, 0.02–30 Hz
MOD SYNC	lock it to the host clock
MOD>SCAN	how much it moves the scan, $\pm 100\%$
MOD>PITCH	how much it bends the pitch
MOD>PAN	how much it moves the voice in the field

ENVELOPE

ATTACK · DECAY · SUSTAIN · RELEASE	1 ms to 10 s on the timed three
VELOCITY	how much velocity decides the level

VOICE

VOICES	POLY (eight) or MONO with legato glide
UNISON	one to four readers per note
DETUNE	how far they are spread in pitch, 0–40 cents
SPREAD	how wide they sit in the stereo field
GLIDE	portamento between notes
TUNE	master tuning, ± 12 semitones
LEVEL	output level

The screens

AXIAL / CORONAL / SAGITTAL	which plane the tomograph cuts
TABLE	the depth of that plane
DENSITY	the gantry's opacity
WINDOW / LEVEL	the width and centre of the display window, both screens
SOLID / SURFACE	how the window is read in the gantry
HOME / ROTATE / ANCHORS	the camera, its spin, and whether the anchors show

Windows, 64-bit. The download holds a VST3 and a standalone. Put `Brain Scan.vst3` in `C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3\` — a subfolder is fine, hosts scan recursively — and rescan in your host. The standalone needs nothing but itself.

The panel is a web view. It needs the Microsoft Edge WebView2 runtime, which is present on every up-to-date Windows 10 and 11. If the panel comes up blank, that runtime is what to install.

It is not signed. Windows may say so on first run, and Smart App Control may refuse an unsigned binary outright; that is a Windows setting, not a fault in the file.

Host notes

- Thirty parameters are automatable, plus five rack macros. SPECIMEN is deliberately not: it rebuilds the volume.
- The scan lines are saved with the project and with a patch, but they are not host parameters. A curve of sixteen points in three dimensions is not a fader.
- F SYNC and MOD SYNC take the host's tempo. With no host clock they fall back to their own

rate.

- MIDI: notes, velocity, pitch bend, sustain, and the modulation wheel.

If something is wrong

- **No sound.** Check the specimen actually has tissue where the WAVE line is — the slice will show you. A line entirely in air reads silence, correctly.
- **A patch sounds different after reloading.** It should not; if it does, that is a bug worth reporting.
- **Everything is buzzing.** RESONANCE with F DEPTH high can find a place in the tissue that sweeps the cutoff faster than it can be believed. That is the instrument working. LEVEL and the limiter in the rack are both downstream.

Brokild plug-ins are free. No licence, no key, no phoning home. They are made for the pleasure of making them.

Brain Scan · Brokild · build 260904.1 ·
peterboggild.github.io/BrokildApps